The three drivers of India's Afghanistan policy—striking a balance between Afghanistan and Pakistan, evolving international political environment, and the changing nature of Afghan domestic politics—determined which of the two policy advocacies won the day to influence policy output. In the early 1990s, the Mujahideen government was an internationally recognised entity that was open to engaging with India despite New Delhi's excessive focus on Najibullah. Moreover, recognising the Mujahideen was also the only possible option that could allow India to strike a balance with Pakistan. Non-engagement would have isolated India further on the Afghan landscape. That its economy had crashed and its international partnerships had unraveled in the face of Soviet disintegration, added weight to the conciliators' advocacy over that of the partisans, regardless of a searing insurgency in Kashmir. Such was, however, not the case in 1996 when the Taliban rose to power. Not only did the Taliban have no international support, it was considered a pariah regime. Despite bringing some degree of stability to the prevalent warlord-ism, it did little to earn world sympathy.

The key policy coup led by the partisans in 1996, however, was India's alignment with Russia, Iran, and the Central Asian Republics to support the United Front morally, financially, and militarily. This was a radical departure from the 1992 Rao doctrine and was squarely aimed against the Pakistan-supported Taliban. Supporting the United Front, which was still the recognised government of Afghanistan at the UN, was viewed as the only viable option to strike a balance between Afghanistan and Pakistan, even if it meant undermining the powerful Kabuliwallah connection with the Pashtun communities. As Narayanan (who was then out of office) observes, this desire to prevent Afghanistan from being 'taken over' by Pakistan put India in an awkward position where it found itself opposing its 'natural allies', i.e. the Pashtuns (who dominated the Taliban movement). Nambiar, who had been in Kabul till 1992 and later worked as Narayanan's deputy NSA in 2005, concurs that the changing situation on the ground in Afghanistan pushed India into developing relations with the non-Pashtuns as a balancing measure against Pakistan's overbearing influence in Afghanistan and increasing pressure against India in that country.[188] In effect, India was trying to run with the hare, and hunt with the hound, by